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ACADEMIC VAULT

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FAA 101: Foundations of Fine and Applied Arts - Drawing, Colour and Form

The studio habits that carry every later course

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Fine & Applied Arts | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack covers observational drawing, proportion and perspective, value and colour theory, composition, and the material differences between drawing, painting, sculpture and design media. It includes a weekly sketchbook routine that builds skill faster than occasional intense sessions.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Draw from observation with correct proportion and simple perspective.
- Use value to describe form and light.
- Apply colour theory in a composition.
- Keep a sketchbook that documents sustained practice.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Observation before expression

Draw what is there before you draw what you feel.

- Sight and measure: use your pencil to compare angles and proportions.
- Block in the largest shapes before detail.
- Check negative space to correct proportion errors.
- One- and two-point perspective for interiors and streets.
- Draw from life daily; photographs flatten form misleadingly.
- Date every page so progress is visible.

Value, light and colour

Value does most of the work of describing form.

- Build a nine-step value scale and use it to check drawings.
- Identify the light source and keep it consistent.
- Look for core shadow, reflected light and cast shadow.
- Colour theory: hue, value, saturation; complementary and analogous schemes.
- Local colour versus perceived colour under light.
- Test colour relationships rather than trusting memory.

> **Squint at it**
> Squinting collapses detail and reveals whether your values hold together. If the drawing collapses, fix the value structure, not the outline.

Media and studio practice

Materials have different affordances; learn them deliberately.

- Graphite: control, shading and erasure.
- Charcoal and conte: bold mass and expressive mark-making.
- Watercolour: transparency, layering and unforgiving corrections.
- Acrylic and oil: opacity, blending and drying differences.
- Clay and relief: form, armature and structural limits.
- Clean up, store work flat and label materials properly.

What art does, and how to talk about it

Fine art is made to be experienced primarily as form and meaning; applied art is made to be used as well. The distinction is institutional rather than absolute - a woven cloth can be both a functional object and a major work - and it changes with context. A masquerade headdress in a museum is fine art; worn in performance it is applied, ritual and social at once.

Analysis of a work begins with description, not judgement. Describe what is there: medium, support, scale, composition, colour, texture, subject, and the marks of making. Only then interpret. The order matters because interpretation without description invents a work that is not in front of you.

Formal elements - line, shape, form, value, colour, texture, space - and principles - balance, contrast, emphasis, rhythm, proportion, unity - are the vocabulary for description. They are not a checklist to be recited; each term should answer a question about how the work produces its effect.

Materials, process and craft